

SINS OF SILENCE

The horrors of Godhra and Ahmedabad in 2002 call for immediate reactivation of the judicial process but they should not be a distraction from the terrifying moral vacuum in the political class

■ By S. Prasannarajan

It is a permanent struggle in the life of nations with a sense of guilt: how to overcome the shame of yesterday. Beneath the placid comfort of the present stir a million ghosts, the unseen remains of our inhumanity. To remember them is to redeem ourselves, and that is the least the living can do to those who were denied dignity in death—and justice even after. There are nations whose abiding identity is built on the blood marks of the past, and whose actions and attitudes are defined by the moral obligations of memory. India is not one of them, not yet. History lies abandoned outside our conscience. Power is incompatible with the politics of morality. The fabled stoicism of the wisest land of the Orient has become the cynicism of an arriviste regional power. Is it that we, dazzled by the sensations in the marketplace and the statistics of the growth rate, as a nation on the fast track can't afford to be snared by the horrors of the past? Or, is it that one of the world's most cited examples of democracy has no moral or emotional content?

We can't be bothered, that too in spite of our freedom's bloody back story, beginning with Partition. India as a nation would remain one territorially but we would continue to be partitioned in so many ways, the pantomime of hate choreographed by gods conjured out of misread scriptures and politicians who tap the raw passions of victimhood and villainy. Calcutta, Jamshedpur, Moradabad, Delhi, Meerut, Bhagalpur, Bombay, Coimbatore, Godhra, Ahmedabad, Marad... These are randomly selected datelines of fear and death, and they invariably tell the same story: hell is the other. Each of them follows the familiar script of violation and transgression, and once the dead are counted and relegated as statistics to government files and the inside pages of newspapers, the story comes to an end with no justice in sight. Ah well, the law takes its own course, but it is such a winding course that seldom we get to see the enormity of the crime being matched by the severity of punishment. There would be more of the same but there would be no mobilisation of conscience.

The embers of Gujarat 2002 reinforce this truism further. What followed in Ahmedabad and

elsewhere in the state after the terror in Godhra, where more than 50 Hindu volunteers returning from Ayodhya in the Sabarmati Express were killed in that inferno of coach S-6, was not a communal riot in the conventional sense, certainly not in the beginning. It was the genocidal rage against a community, and the administration of Narendra Modi was not effective in its initial reaction to the carnage. The administrative failure was appalling. And remember it happened in a state with a history of religious hate; the communal fault lines on the Sabarmati were pretty glaring when armed mobs maimed, burnt and killed. After Ayodhya, Ahmedabad was the international story on the 'horrors of Hindu nationalism'—"Vegetarians Roast Humans", read one anguished headline. Modi became the new four-letter word in the Left-liberal glossary of evil—a Hindu fuhrer for quite a few commentators. In spite of cultural caricaturing and lazy invocation of the Holocaust, Gujarat made all of us smaller. It happened a few months after 9/11, an event that introduced the new century to the evil of faith, to the murderous profanity of religion. Gujarat was India's moment to be ashamed—and awakened. As Salman Rushdie wrote then, "So India's problem turns out to be the world's problem. What happened in India, happened in God's name. The problem's name is God."

Now, thanks to an intrepid reporter armed with a spy cam and a false identity, we have the names and faces and words of some of those political perverts who were in the vanguard of the Gujarat massacre. In spite of the occasional flourish of pamphleteering in the reportage and the one-dimensionality of truth (there might have been some Hindu victims too, and hence some Muslim villains as well, right?), what the sting operation brings out is chilling in its savagery. The braggadocio of some of those barbarians may be explained by the fact that the *Tehelka* reporter had posed as a fellow zealot who was writing a thesis on Hindutva. The revelations, nevertheless, are the first testaments of the killers, and the enormity of their crime makes them obvious outcasts in any civilised society. What happened in the wake of Godhra was not spontaneous rage of the fanatic Hindu but, in the words of the killer, a well-planned political operation, the religious cleanser aware of his power and

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